Damned

By Chuck Palahniuk

MADISON: **(Pg 3-4)** Being ***dead***-dead means nonstop, twenty-four/seven, three hundred sixty-five days a year . . . forever. Probably I shouldn't even tell you I'm dead, because no doubt now you feel awfully superior. Nevertheless, here it is: my Hideous Admission. In a world where people say you're lazy for not shaving your legs, being dead seems like the ultimate character flaw. [But] I'll fess up and come clean. I'm out of the closet. I'm dead. **(Pg 8)** Disregard my account of Hell at your own peril.

INTRODUCTION

Madison has problems: she's overweight, ignored by her parents, and she's dead. But not just dead. Madison is in Hell, which really does exist! It's a place where your only career choice is telemarketer, and the only currency is Halloween candy. This is the afterlife as only Chuck Palahniuk could imagine it: a twisted inferno where The English Patient *plays on endless repeat, and roaming demons devour sinners limb by limb. He makes eternal torment, well, simply divine.*

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MADISON: **(Pg 8)** First off, you wake up lying on the stone floor inside a fairly dismal cell composed of iron bars. The bars look a tad slimy with mold and someone else's blood. Don't touch anything. And do NOT eat the candy you'll see scattered everywhere on the ground. (Pg 104) [See] Jewls and cash are worthless here. The currency is candy., and marshmallow peanuts are accepted as payment for all bribes and debts. The hellish equivalent of pennies are popcorn balls . . . black licorice . . . was lips . . . and these are cast aside in disdain. [But] Root Beer Barrels are as valuable as rubies.

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(Pg 16) ***Are you there, Satan? It's me, Madison. Please don't feel hurt, but my parents raised me to believe you didn't exist. [They] said you and God were invented in the brains of hillbilly preachers and Republican(s).***

(Pg 83) You can't turn around in Hell without elbowing somebody important. Marilyn Monroe, Clarence Darrow, John F. Kennedy, John Lennon. **(Pg 108)** 98.3 percent of lawyers end up in Hell, and [while] a trace number of politicians ascend to Heaven, statistically speaking, 100 percent of them are cast into the fiery pit. As are essentially 100 percent of journalist and redheads. **(Pg 83)** If he knew the networking opportunities here, my dad would immediately gulp down rat poison.

(Pg 90) As it turns out, my damnnation records have been lost . . . or accidentally destroyed. **(Pg 94)** It seems only fair that I ought to appeal my own eternal sentence. **(Pg 185)** [I] trudge across the Great Plains of Broken Glass, [wade] the River of Steaming-hot Vomit, [trek] across the vast Valley of Used Disposable Diapers toward the headquarters of Hell, [where] **(Pg 90)** I'm forced to start from scratch, assigned to take a basic lie-detector test. **(Pg 86)** ***Are you there, Satan? It's me, Madison. I've never been very adept at taking tests.***

A demon with cat's claws and folded leathery wings leans close to adjust a blood-pressure cuff which is wrapped around my upper arm. **(Pg 90)** You might recall this same demon from the classic Hollywood masterpiece the Exorcist.

DEMON: **(Pg 92-94)** Do you believe the Bible to be the one and only true word of God?

MADISON: Does that include the way-crazy, loony parts of Leviticus?

DEMON: In your honest opinion, does life begin at conception?

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MADISON: *(nervously wipes the sweat from her brow, grinds her teeth, clenches her fists, she cautiously answers)* Yes?

DEMON: Do you view sexual acts between individuals of the same gender to be an abomination?

MADISON: Can we come back to that question later?

DEMON: I'll take that as a "no"

MADISON: *(to audience)* Yes, I do want to go to Heaven – who doesn't? – but not if it means I have to be a total ass.

DEMON: Do you approve of marriage between individuals of differing racial backgrounds? *(without waiting for answer)* Should the Zionist state of Israel be allowed to exist?

MADISON: *(to audience)* I'm stumped. Even fingers crossed. The paradox: Is God a racist, homophobic, anti-Semitic ass? Or is God testing to see if I am? [Then] in the same tone that a fast-food server would ask, "Do you want fries with that?" the demon asks . . .

DEMON: Are you, yourself, a virgin? *(Madison freezes and refuses to answer, a guilty look on her face)*

MADISON: [Who knows how long it will take to get my results]

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MADISON: **(Pg 104-105)** The dirty little secret about Hell is that the demons are always running tabs on you. If you breathe their air, the powers that be are constantly dinging you for the cost. No, it's not fair, but the demons charge you for your upkeep. Most people are condemned for only a few eons, but they accrue additional time simply by occupying space in Hell. [So] if you have any aspirations to earn your daily Junior Mints, you need to find a career and get working! **(Pg 103)** ***Are you there, Satan? It's me, Madison. I'm proud to say that I've obtained full-time employment. A***

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genuine job. As of now I' a regular working stiff – if you'll pardon the terrible pun. The work which most people do in Hell is – telemarketing. The dark forces are constantly calculating when it's dinnertime and a computer autodials those phone numbers so I can interrupt everyone's meal. I just ask if you have a few seconds to take part in a market research study identifying consumer trends in chewing gum. In mouthwash. In dryer fabric-softener sheets. I get to talk to real-live people – like yourself – who have no idea that I'm dead and phoning them from the Afterlife. Trust me, the vast majority of telemarketing people who ring you up, they're dead. **(Pg 109-110)** [But] even as a telemarketer, it's best not to enjoy yourself too much. If you don't look miserable, the demons will reseat you next to someone who whistles. Then next to someone who farts.

(Pg 122) ***Are you there, Satan? It's me, Madison. Over the phone today, I made a new friend. She's not dead, not yet, but I can tell we're going to be way-total best friends.*** **(Pg 124)** *(On the telephone)* If the Big C does kill [you] and [you] end up in the pit. Look me up. I'm Maddy Spencer, Phone bank number 3, 717, 021, position 12. Good luck with [your] chemo. Now remember, ask for Madison Spencer. I'll show you the ropes! *(hangs up and the autodialer connects her with the next caller)* **(Pg 125-126)** We're conducting a consumer survey to track purchase patterns for common household items . . . **(Pg 109)** Would [you] consider purchasing toothpicks artificially treated to taste like chocolate? *(Marks sheet)* Like beef? *(marks sheet)* Like apples *(marks sheet) (to audience)* **(Pg 126)** I meet a girl about my same age, who's dying from AIDS. Her name is Emily. [She won't believe me at first] Either about being her same age or about being dead. It ought to break my heart, talking to a girl who's dying of AIDS with both her

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parents at work while she watches television and feels weaker every day, but at least Emily's still alive.

EMILY: Not only [am I] still alive, but [I] have no intention of ending up in Hell.

MADISON: [Have you] ever used the word "ain't"? [Have you] ever fixed a hem with a safety pin or tape? Well, I've met mobs of people condemned to eternal hell fire for just those very slipups. Best not count [your] chickens before they're hatched. 100 percent of people who die of AIDS are consigned to Hell. And all people killed by drunk drivers This is Hell – don't ask for too much logic.

EMILY: *(continually coughing)* AIDS isn't [my] fault. Besides that, [I'm] not going to die, not for a long, long time. *(She coughs again, which turns into sobs, sniffing and weeping)* You're lying!

MADISON: *(without any emotion)* It's not fair. You'll see. *(Emily hangs up on her, and Madison is offended. Phone immediately rings on Madison's desk, she answers)* **(Pg 134-136)** Hello?

EMILY: Is this Maddy? Are you Madison Spencer?

MADISON: Who's calling?

EMILY: Emily.

MADISON: *(covering the receiver to speak to the audience)* She *69'd me!

EMILY: My parents want me to see a new shrink. Do you think I should go?

MADISON: *(Shaking her head)* No way. And don't let them feed you full of Xanax, either! What's is like to have AIDS?

EMILY: *(Rolling her eyes)* It's like being Canadian. You get used to it.

MADISON: *(Trying to sound impressed)* Wow. I guess people can get used to pretty much anything.

EMILY: How did you die?

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MADISON: I'm not all together certain. *(uncomfortable talking about herself, she changes the subject)* **(Pg 127)** Look me up once [you] arrive. We'll make a bet. Ten Milky Way bars says [you're] down here with me faster than [you] can imagine. Ask anybody for directions. The name's Maddy Spencer, and [you] need to make sure and die with ten candy bars in [your] pocket. Ten! ***Not snack-size!***

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MADISON: **(Pg 224)** ***Are you there, Satan? It's me, Madison. I [am] planning a little pilgrimage back to hobnob among the living. And to plunder the earth for its wealth of candy.*** Halloween is the only regular occasion on which the dead of Hell can revisit the living on earth. From dusk until midnight, the damned may walk – fully visible – among the living. The fun ends with the stroke of midnight; and like Cinderella, missing that curfew merits a special punishment. Any tardy souls are forced to wander the earth for a year, until dusk of the next Halloween – loitering among the self-obsessed living for twelve boring months. **(Pg 184)** Anytime your stomach is rumbling, or when you feel a sudden craving to eat something sweet, that's someone in the afterlife who's attempting to communicate with you. Cold sores on your lips . . . a bouncing, restless leg . . . ingrown hairs – all methods that dead people use to gain your attention. **(Pg 226)** [But] on Halloween, custom requires the dead to not merely revisit the earth, but to do so in the guise of their former lives.

EMILY: Forget that! I'm not trick-or-treating as a dumb Canadian girl with AIDS. I'm going to be a fairy princess.

MADISON: [Since] **(Pg 90)** my damnnation records have been lost, **(Pg 226)** I consider appearing as some stock character: a genie or angel or ghost. This is the first Halloween since my demise . . . *(Madison pushes the doorbell on a house*

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and waits impatiently for it to open) **(Pg 237)** Trick or treat! *(Looking in her bag)* **(Pg 224)** Candy corn! Tootsie Rolls! Bit-O-Honey!

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MADISON: **(Pg 246-247)** To anyone who isn't already dead, I wish you luck. Honestly, I do. You just keep swallowing your vitamins . . . Keep jogging around reservoirs and voiding secondhand cigarette smoke. Cross your fingers . . . maybe death won't happen to you. Please don't be afraid. If you go to Heaven, bully for you. But if you don't – well, look me up. The only thing that makes earth feel like Hell, or Hell feel like Hell, is our expectation that it ought to feel like Heaven. Earth is earth. Dead is dead. [It's almost midnight, so I have to go] *(Madison stuffs a candybar in her mouth and talks with it full)* **(Pg 1)** ***Are you there Satan, it's me Madison.***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Chuck Palahniuk
ISBN: 978-0307476531
Publisher: Anchor
Date (Month/Year): October 2012

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier

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